

KATHA STUDIO

Monsoon Meera

When the village well cracks dry, a girl who can hear clouds must walk the old rain-road, bargain with a sulking monsoon, and teach a whole generation the song they forgot.

Book 01 · Folk fantasy · Kerala backwaters

Lead: Meera Rainbinder · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading



Alappuzha. Forty-one days without a honest drop.

Paddy fields lie like cracked pottery. Coconut palms rattle with a thirst that has begun to sound like argument. In the lane, water is counted in steel tumblers and sideways looks.

NARRATOR

“The well sang once. Now it only coughs dust.”

DRY WIND



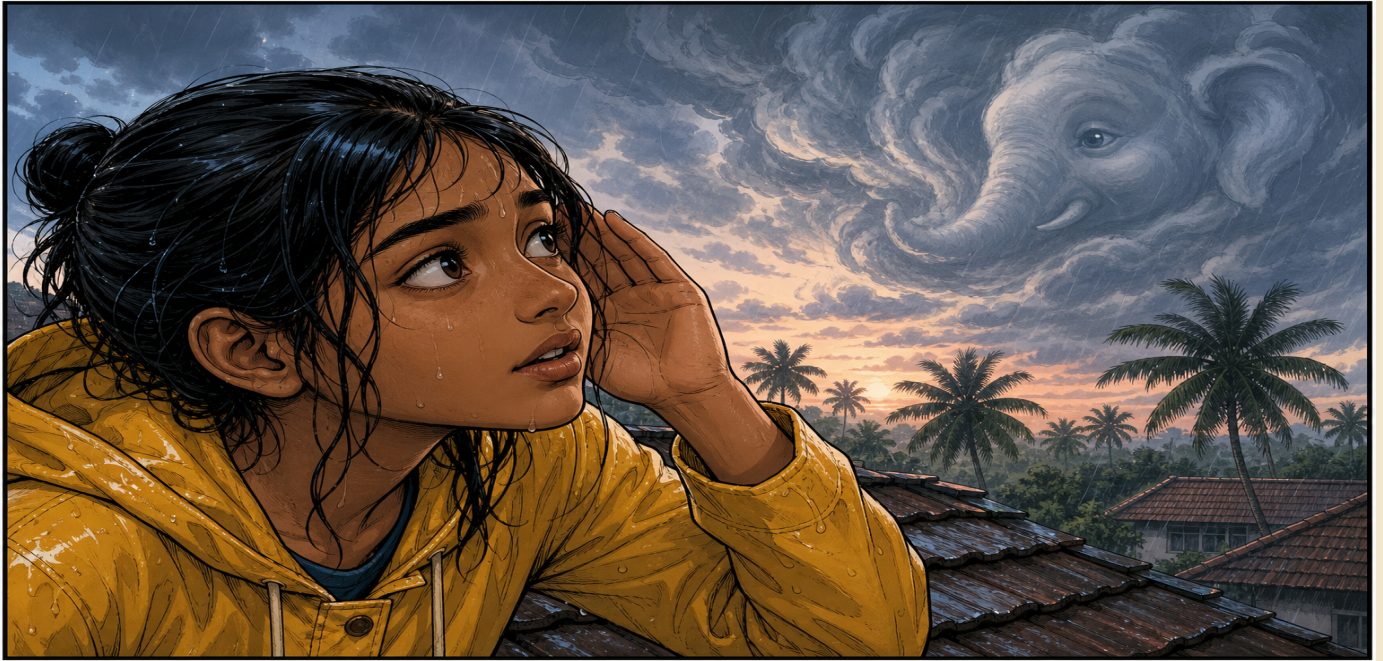
Amma rations tea as if it were medicine, because it nearly is.

Meera's mother has survived worse summers, but never one that made the temple pond look ashamed. She hides worry in extra pickle and in telling her daughter to stay practical.

AMMA

"If you climb that roof again, the sky will think we are beggars."

CLINK



Meera climbs anyway. Roofs, in her family, have always been a kind of pulpit.

Dawn makes the tiles look like wet coins even when they are dry. Meera cups her ear toward a bruise-coloured cloud that has been circling the backwaters like a thought nobody wants to finish.

MEERA

“I can hear you sulking. Come down and argue properly.”

DRIP



The monsoon answers with elephant patience and a child's temper.

It is not a god exactly, and not a weather report. It is weather with a memory. It remembers processions, it remembers roofs painted with rice-flour, it remembers being thanked.

MONSOON

“They forgot the old songs. Why should I remember their fields?”

RUMBLE



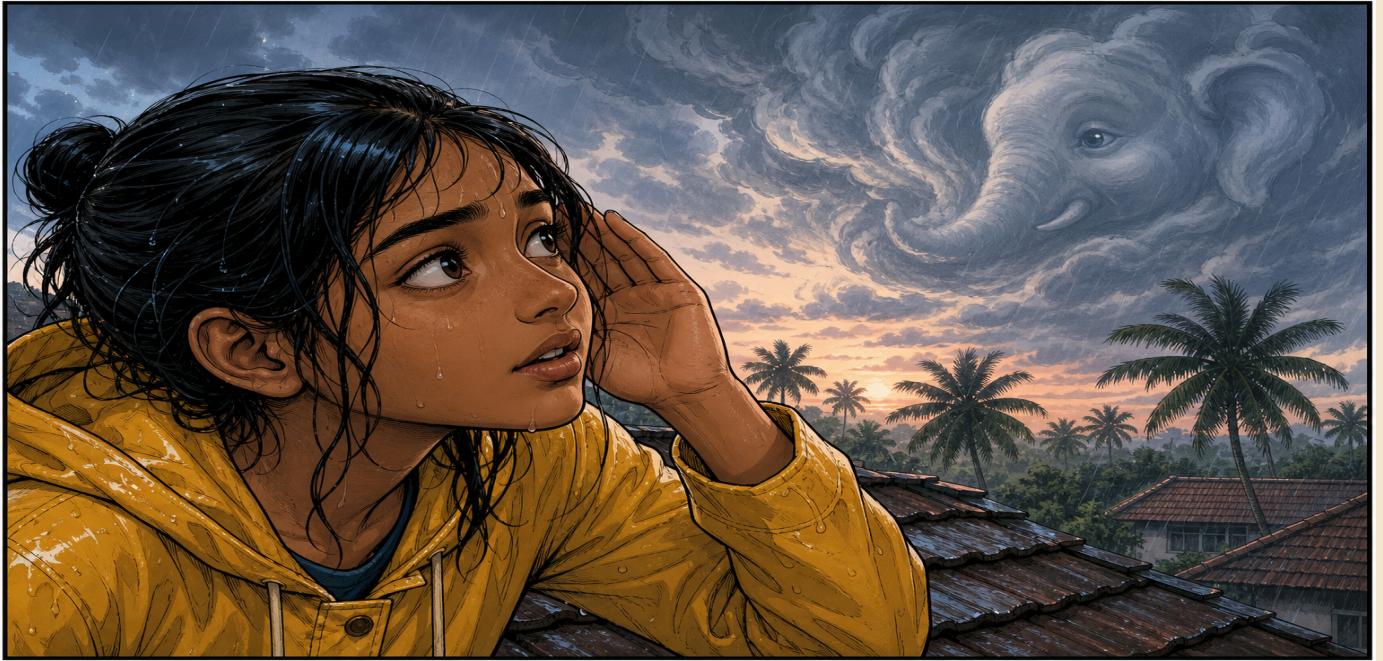
Amma finds her on the steps with salt on her eyelashes that is not from the sea.

Meera tells her the truth in the smallest possible sentences. Amma does not laugh. In this village, strange things are only strange the first time they save a crop.

AMMA

“Talking to clouds will not fill a pot.”

HUSH



The bargain begins the way all Kerala bargains begin: with insult, then tea, then terms.

The monsoon wants a chorus. Not a museum song, not a school-function song. The one grandmothers used when the first rain smelled like hot earth and crushed pepper.

MEERA

“If they forget, I will remind them. If you forget, I will shout until the sky gets embarrassed.”

CRACK



Meera walks the rain-road: jetty, shrine, the house of the woman who still keeps a rain-drum.

Old Leelamma's wrists remember rhythms her tongue claims to have lost. She teaches Meera three beats and a pause that means please without kneeling.

MEERA

"Loan me the drum. I will return it louder."

TAP TAP



Children are terrible at reverence and excellent at repetition.

In the temple courtyard Meera drills a choir of cousins, ferry-boys, and one extremely serious goat. The song returns like a relative who swore they would never visit and then brought sweets.

CHILD

“Again! The part where the cloud gets scolded!”

SPLASH



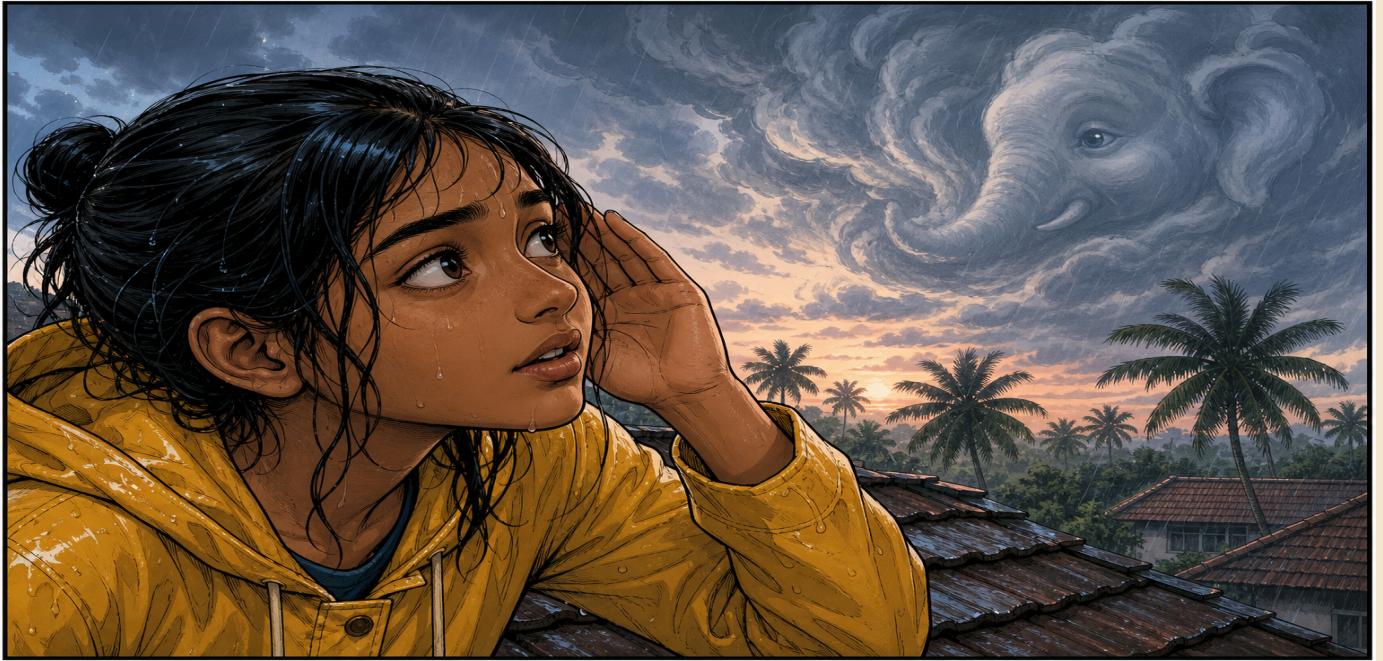
A contractor arrives with bottled water and a smile that invoices the future.

He wants the dry well as proof that the village must sell its bank to a private tank. Meera's monsoon bristles. Weather hates being used as a sales chart.

CONTRACTOR

“Forget folklore. Sign here. I will pipe you civilisation.”

STAMP



Meera refuses the pen. The cloud refuses the man's umbrella.

The contractor's papers wilt without rain, which is a petty miracle and therefore the best kind. He leaves promising lawyers. The goat remains unimpressed.

MEERA

“Civilisation here still knows how to share a tumbler.”

NO



Night. Amma sets out a fourth cup, empty, for a guest who is not a person.

Hospitality is the village's oldest technology. Meera understands, suddenly, that the song was never magic. It was a way of making room.

AMMA

“If it comes in, wipe its feet. I just swept.”

STEAM



The monsoon tests them with a wind that knocks the drum into the canal.

Meera dives. Canal water in a drought is a muddy argument. She comes up with the drum and a leech on her ankle, which she names temporarily after the contractor.

MONSOON

“Retrieve it without complaining, and I will consider being weather again.”

WHOOSH



The first true rain arrives like a rumour that turns out to be a wedding.

People shout. People laugh. Someone starts the song wrong and is lovingly bullied into the right key. The well does not overflow yet; it only remembers how.

NARRATOR

“Dust learns, in one afternoon, how to be mud with opinions.”

DOWNPOUR



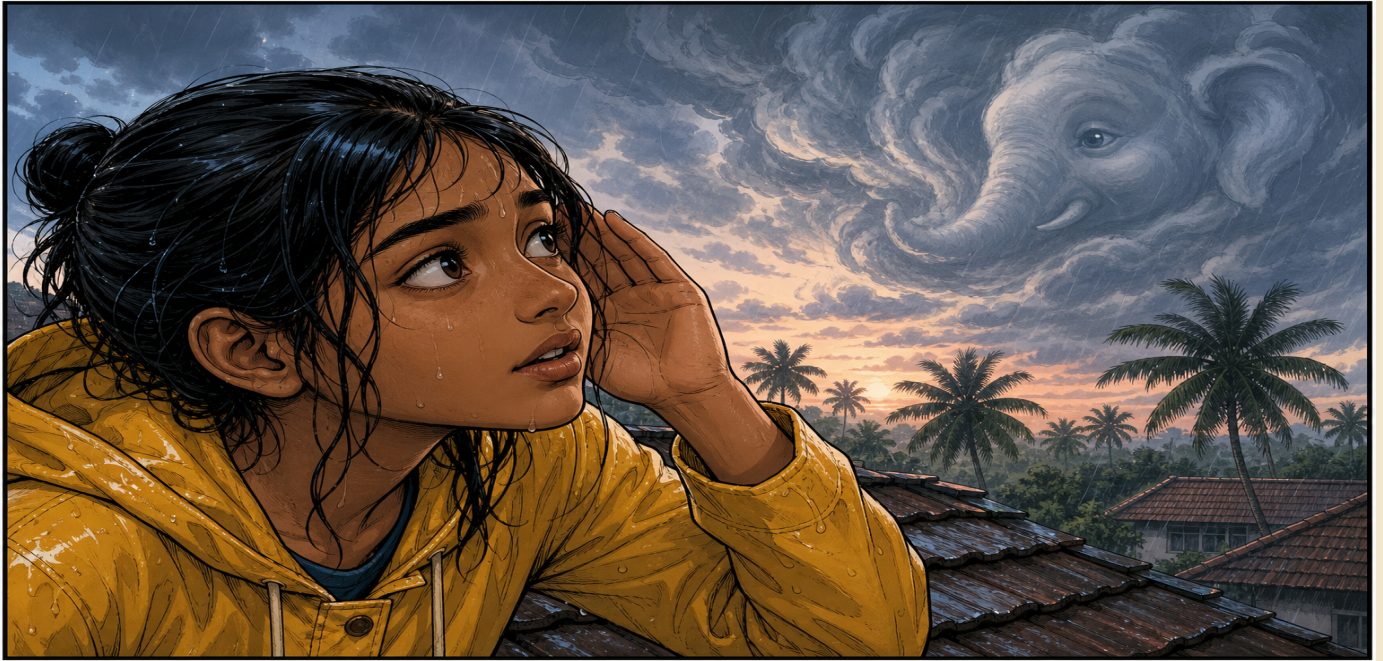
Banana leaves become drums. The goat finally keeps time.

Meera does not dance at first. She watches the cloud's face for cheating. Finding none, she lets herself be sixteen and soaked and loudly incorrect about the lyrics.

AMMA

“That girl talks to weather like it owes her rent.”

THUNDER



At the height of the storm the monsoon asks for one more term.

Meera looks at the children, at Amma, at the drum. She nods the way you nod when you accept a job that will never pay in rupees and will always pay in mango season.

MONSOON

“Keep a listener in every generation. I will not audition twice.”

BOOM



Morning after. The world smells like iron, earth, and fried shallots.

They eat in wet clothes because dry clothes are a tomorrow problem. Outside, frogs hold a meeting more organised than the panchayat.

AMMA

“Eat. Saving a village is not an excuse to skip breakfast.”

SIZZLE



The contractor's boat returns, sees the full well, and develops a sudden interest in other districts.

It is not a legal argument. It is better. The village copies the rain-song into school copybooks beside multiplication tables.

MEERA

“Tell your lawyers the sky already signed.”

HONK



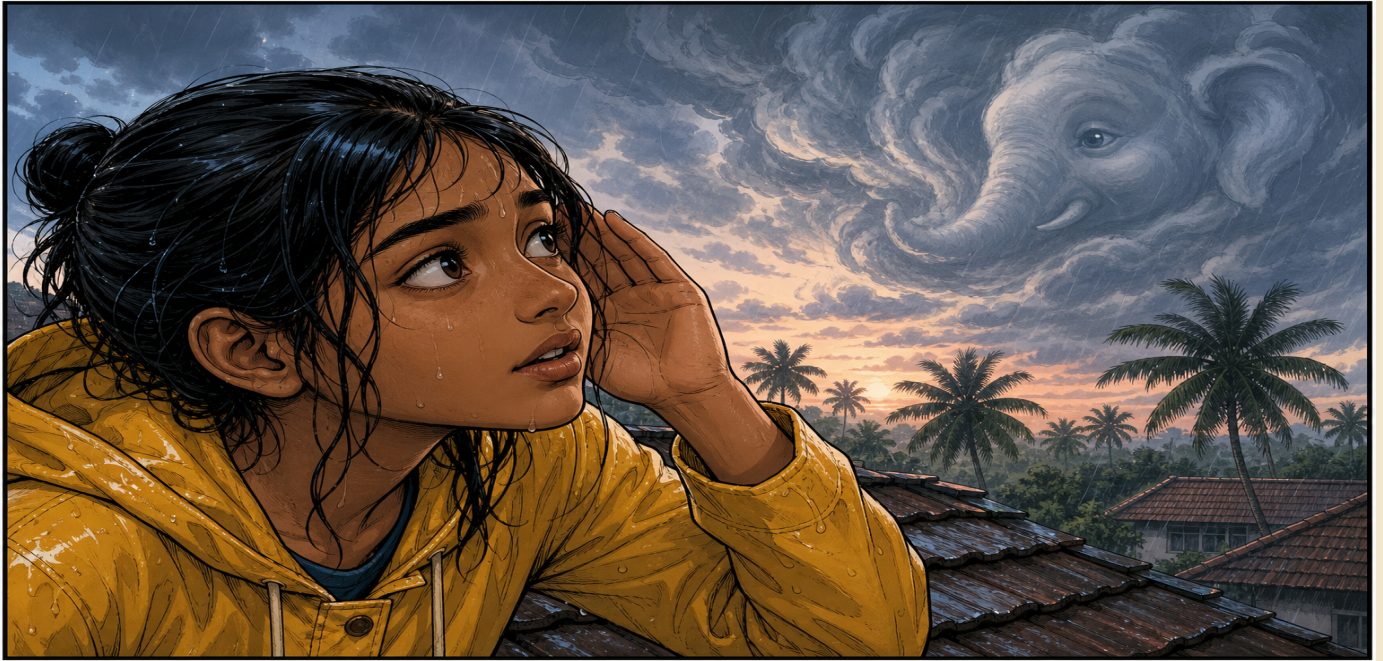
On the forty-second dusk, the well overflows and nobody pretends to be dignified.

Meera teaches them the pause instead, the please. Lightning, she says, is just the sky showing off, and showing off should never be the chorus.

CHILD

“Meera akka, teach the part that makes lightning clap.”

LAUGH



The monsoon leaves a raindrop on Meera's earring that refuses to evaporate.

It hangs there like a second ear. On dry days it ticks, faintly, to remind her that weather is a relationship, not a season.

MONSOON

“Call me when they forget. I like being argued with.”

SOFT RAIN



Weeks later, a girl from the next jetty arrives with a cracked pot and a rumour.

Amma looks at Meera. Meera looks at the drum. The goat looks like it is updating its calendar.

VISITOR

“They say you can scold clouds. Ours has been rude for a month.”

KNOCK



Meera packs pickle, the rain-drum, and a voice already hoarse from practice.

The backwaters stitch villages together more honestly than roads. She takes the ferry knowing the job is larger than one well, and lighter than despair.

MEERA

“I am not a goddess. I am a reminder with good lungs.”

FOOTSTEPS



Somewhere over the palms, a cloud keeps pace, pretending not to follow.

The fields drink. The well sings under its breath. And a girl in a yellow raincoat walks the rain-road with an argument already prepared, just in case the sky gets proud again.

NARRATOR

“Thus begins the quiet career of Monsoon Meera, listener-for-hire.”

DISTANT THUNDER